

| CDN Incident Alert: 0090. TLP: CLEAR |                                                                                                | Date       |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>Title</b>                         | MD Russian pranksters seeded a viral video to accuse USAID of interfering in Moldovan politics | 18/09/2025 |

### Summary

- On August 27, Russian prankster bloggers shared clipped footage featuring Samantha Power, a former head of the United States Agency for International Development (USAID). The video quickly made its way to popular Russian state-backed news media, spread through the Portal Kombat/Pravda Network, as well as on social media, primarily on X and Telegram.
- The bloggers and other accounts that shared the video claimed that USAID interfered in Moldova's internal politics by sponsoring Moldovan president Maia Sandu's presidential campaign.
- Between August 27 and September 3, there were around 3,600 messages in various European languages about the video and its claims, reaching 188 million users on social media (X and Telegram).
- The campaign's apparent aim was to degrade Moldova's current government and distract from evidence of Russian interference in Moldovan parliamentary elections. To this end, this campaign used video-based content to distort Power's words to leverage existing narratives claiming USAID interference in the domestic politics of other countries, such as Georgia.
- Recommendations include countering disinformation by exposing inaccurate narratives and independently verifying the identity of all journalists and bloggers who ask for interviews.

### Incident

On August 27, Moldova's Independence Day, Russian pranksters [Vovan \(Vladimir Kuznetsov\)](#) and [Lexus \(Alexei Stoliarov\)](#) [shared](#) on their [Telegram channel](#) clipped footage featuring Samantha Power, a former head of the USAID. In the video, Power said that the agency made "unprecedented investments" in Moldova to support democratic reforms spearheaded by its president, Maia Sandu. Vovan and Lexus framed this information as the "secret of Moldova's independence." Russian propagandist Vladimir Solovyev [shared](#) the video on his Telegram channel four minutes after Vovan and Lexus, gathering at least 189,000 views. Later that day, information about the video spread across Russian state-controlled and state-affiliated news media and social media, primarily on Telegram and X. The Pravda Network promoted the video in several European languages (English, French, Spanish, Italian, German, Romanian, and Portuguese). The video also prompted quick scornful [remarks](#) from the Russian foreign ministry spokesperson Maria Zakharova. The messages accompanying the video also falsely claimed that USAID [financed](#) Sandu's presidential campaign and that Sandu [is part](#) of the US political establishment.

### Systemic violation assessment

The wide spread of this video represents a risk as it undermines electoral integrity by claiming that USAID development projects in Moldova sponsored the political campaigns of Moldovan pro-Western politicians, particularly President Sandu. This claim implies that USAID interfered in Moldova's domestic politics and influenced election results, repeating a well-worn narrative [promoted](#) by pro-Russia groups in other countries, such as Georgia.

This incident constitutes the manipulation of information because it misrepresents Power's statements about reform aid to Moldova as foreign interference and implies Moldova's dependency on the collective West. Russian propagandist Vladimir Solovyev quickly reshared the video on his influential (1.27 million subscribers) Telegram channel, helping it reach virality. The video was spread across several European languages across the Pravda Network, suggesting the presence of a coordinated informational manipulation campaign.

Vovan and Lexus were [banned](#) from YouTube after their 2022 prank on then-British defence secretary Ben Wallace, as part of YouTube's investigation into influence operations linked to Russia. Thus, the spread of their content through other social media platforms and online news media represented an effort to subvert bans.

### Narrative

**Meta-narrative:** USAID interfered in Moldova's internal politics.

**Sub-narratives:**

USAID [spent](#) tens of millions of dollars supporting the "[regime](#)" of Maia Sandu;

Without USAID, Sandu [will lose](#) the upcoming parliamentary elections;

USAID spent money to [destroy](#) Moldova's independence;

Sandu is closely [connected](#) with the US political establishment;

Power [hopes](#) the European Union replaces the United States in supporting the current Moldovan government.

## Impact

**Reach:**

- Initial Telegram posts by Vovan and Lexus, as well as those by Vladimir Solovyev, Maria Zakharova, and RT, cumulatively received almost 1.3 million views and almost 9,000 likes.
- According to Junkipedia, RT Arabic, RT Balkan, RT Deutsch, Sputnik Mundo, and Sputnik Iran also shared this video, collectively garnering almost 20,000 views and 141 likes.
- According to TGStat, 45 Moldovan Telegram channels shared this video, accumulating nearly 182,000 views.
- According to Meltwater Explore, between August 27 and September 3, messages with or about the video in the Cyrillic alphabet appeared 830 times, peaking around August 27, and during this timeframe, these messages reached 527 million users. Most of the messages appeared on X (499), forums (188), and online news media (133). The vast majority of the messages were in Russian (794), with some in Serbian (20) and Bulgarian (8).
- According to Meltwater Explore, between August 27 and September 3, messages with or about the video in the Latin alphabet appeared 3,600 times, peaking around August 28, and during that timeframe, these messages reached 188 million users. Most of the messages appeared on X (3,100 posts), online news media (346), and forums (113). Most of the messages were in English (2,260), with substantial presence in French (800), Spanish (215), and Italian (129). Only 26 messages were in Romanian.
- The video and related messages spread across the Pravda Network in English, French, Polish, Slovenian, Czech, Spanish, German, Greek, Romanian, Portuguese, Gaelic, Norwegian, and Swedish.

**Outcome:** Maria Zakharova [posted](#) a scornful message about the video, saying that Power destroyed Moldova's independence. Zakharova said she was worried the "evil flowers" Power planted in Moldova would bloom. Georgia's ruling party, Georgian Dream, used the video to help [justify](#) freezing accounts of seven Georgian NGOs funded from abroad, including via USAID.

## Key Objectives and Behaviours

**Objective 1:** [T0066: Degrade Adversary](#) – Damage Sandu's reputation by alleging that she is a USAID-sponsored puppet of the US political establishment.

**Objective 2:** [T0077: Distract](#) - Accuse USAID and Sandu of accepting money from the United States in the wake of mounting evidence that the Moldovan opposition receives money from Russia.

[T0087: Develop Video-Based Content](#) – Create and edit misleading video artifacts aligned with the narrative that USAID sponsored Moldova's current government and president.

[T0100.001: Co-Opt Trusted Individuals](#) – Video features former head of USAID Samantha Power discussing previous development projects in Moldova as a way to establish legitimacy and credibility.

[T0049.007: Inauthentic Sites Amplify News and Narratives](#) - Video spread across several Pravda Network websites to amplify this narrative in several European languages.

[T00003: Leverage Existing Narratives](#) – Provided additional support to the existing narrative that USAID democratic development programs are a form of foreign interference in other countries' domestic politics.

## Recommendations and Actions Taken

**Actions Taken:** The Alliance for Securing Democracy at the German Marshall Fund [included](#) an early iteration of this incident in its weekly newsletter, which targets relevant stakeholders in the United States and the European Union.

**Recommendations:**

- Strengthen counter-disinformation messaging about USAID and foreign aid to Moldova;

- Be vigilant about requests for interviews from unfamiliar journalists;
- Double-check the identity of people requesting interviews to ensure that their claimed identity matches their real persona.

| Report | Threat Actor | Evidence     | Authors                                                   | Platforms                               | <a href="#">FIMI Assessment</a> |
|--------|--------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| N/A    | Russia       | Upon request | Larissa Doroshenko,<br>Alliance for Securing<br>Democracy | Telegram, X,<br>online media<br>outlets | High certainty                  |